

Math 121: Commutative Algebra

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Worksheet 4.1: Modules Pt. I

Throughout this course, “ring” means *commutative* ring with unity. In this worksheet $\mathbb{K}$ will denote a field. A *R -module* is an abelian group $(M, +)$ together with a scalar multiplication $R \times M \rightarrow M, (r, m) \mapsto rm$, satisfying the following:

- (i) Associativity: $(rs)m = r(sm)$ for all $r, s \in R$ and $m \in M$,
- (ii) Distribution over R : $(r + s)m = rm + sm$ for all $r, s \in R$ and $m \in M$,
- (iii) Distribution over M : $r(m + n) = rm + rn$ for all $r \in R$ and $m, n \in M$, and
- (iv) Identity: $1_R m = m$ for all $m \in M$.

Since M is an abelian group, it has a distinguished additive identity, which we normally denote by 0 or by 0_M if we need to distinguish it from 0_R . When the base ring is clear from context, we might simply say that M is a module, or we might say that M is a module over R . As we will see, modules are the analogue of vector spaces in which the scalars come from a ring instead of a field. They include ideals, quotient rings, abelian groups, vector spaces, and many other naturally occurring algebraic objects.

If M is an R -module, a subset $N \subseteq M$ is an *R -submodule* of M if and only if $rm + sn \in N$ for all $r, s \in R$ and $m, n \in N$. That is, a submodule is a subgroup of M such that the scalar multiplication of R on M restricts to a scalar multiplication on N .

Problem 1. Basic Identities. Let R be a ring and M an R -module. Prove the following identities.

1. $r0_M = 0_M$ for all $r \in R$.
2. $0_R m = 0_M$ for all $m \in M$.
3. $(-r)m = r(-m)$ for all $r \in R$ and all $m \in M$.

Solution.

1. Let $m \in M$.

$$r0_M = r(m - m) = rm - rm = 0_M$$

2. Let $r \in R$.

$$0_R m = (r - r)m = rm - rm = 0_M$$

- 3.

$$(-r)m = (0_R - r)m = 0_R m - rm$$

From (ii) we have that $0_R m = 0_M$,

$$\begin{aligned} (-r)m &= 0_R m - rm = 0_M - rm \\ &= 0_M r - rm = r(0_M - m) \\ &= r(-m) \end{aligned}$$

Problem 3. Submodules Generated by Elements.

Let M be an R -module. Given elements $m_1, \dots, m_t \in M$, the submodule of M generated by $m_1, \dots, m_t$ is the set

$$Rm_1 + Rm_2 + \cdots + Rm_t := \{r_1m_1 + \cdots + r_tm_t \mid r_1, \dots, r_t \in R\} \subseteq M.$$

We say that $m_1, \dots, m_t$ are *generators* for M if $Rm_1 + Rm_2 + \cdots + Rm_t = M$. A submodule $N \subseteq M$ is a *cyclic submodule* if $N = Rm$ for some $m \in M$.

1. Prove that $Rm_1 + Rm_2 + \cdots + Rm_t$ is an R -submodule of M .
2. Prove that $Rm_1 + Rm_2 + \cdots + Rm_t$ is the smallest R -submodule of M containing $m_1, \dots, m_t$.
3. Prove that a ring R is itself a cyclic R -module by finding a generator.
4. In the $\mathbb{Z}$ -module $\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z}$, compute the submodules generated by $\bar{8}$ and $\bar{6}$.
5. Let $R = \mathbb{K}[x]$ and $M = R/\langle x^3 \rangle$. Describe the submodules generated by $\bar{1}$, $\bar{x}$, and $\bar{x}^2$.

Solution.

Let $N = Rm_1 + Rm_2 + \cdots + Rm_t$.

1. Let $r, s \in R$ and $n, m \in N$. Then, by definition

$$m = r_1m_1 + \cdots + r_tm_t$$

and

$$n = s_1m_1 + \cdots + s_tm_t$$

with $r_1, \dots, r_t, s_1, \dots, s_t \in R$. Then by distributivity and associativity of R , and the abelian nature of M we have,

$$\begin{aligned} pm + qn &= p(r_1m_1 + \cdots + r_tm_t) + q(s_1m_1 + \cdots + s_tm_t) \\ &= ((pr_1)m_1 + \cdots + (pr_t)m_t) + ((qs_1)m_1 + \cdots + (qs_t)m_t) \\ &= ((pr_1 + qs_1)m_1 + \cdots + (pr_t + qs_t)m_t) \end{aligned}$$

but since R is closed under addition and multiplication $pr_1 + qs_1, \dots, pr_t + qs_t \in R$. Hence, $pm + qn \in N$ and N is a submodule.

2. Let L be the smallest R -submodule of M containing $m_1, \dots, m_t$. Then by minimality of L we have $L \subseteq N$. To show the reverse containment consider $m \in N$. By definition,

$$m = r_1m_1 + \cdots + r_tm_t$$

with $r_1, \dots, r_t \in R$. But since $m_1, \dots, m_t \in L$, all R -linear combinations of them is in L (by definition of a submodule), hence $m \in L$. Since m was an arbitrary element in N this implies that $N = L$, hence N is the smallest R -submodule of M containing $m_1, \dots, m_t$.

3. The ring R is a cyclic R -module with the generator 1_R .

By definition,

$$R \cdot 1_R = \{r \cdot 1_R \mid r \in R\}$$

But $r \cdot 1_R = r$ for all $r \in R$, i.e., $R \cdot 1_R = R$.

4. Consider $\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z} \cdot \bar{8}$,

$$\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z} \cdot \bar{8} = \{r \cdot \bar{8} \mid r \in \mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z}\} = \{\bar{0}, \bar{8}, \bar{4}\}$$

Consider $\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z} \cdot \bar{6}$,

$$\mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z} \cdot \bar{6} = \{r \cdot \bar{6} \mid r \in \mathbb{Z}/12\mathbb{Z}\} = \{\bar{0}, \bar{6}\}$$

5. $R \cdot \bar{1} = \{r \cdot \bar{1} = \bar{r} \mid r \in R\} = M$

$$R \cdot \bar{x} = \{r \cdot \bar{x} = \overline{rx} \mid r \in R\} = \{\overline{r_1x + r_2x^2} \mid r_1, r_2 \in R\} = \mathbb{K} \cdot \bar{x}$$

$$R \cdot \bar{x}^2 = \{r \cdot \bar{x}^2 = \overline{rx^2} \mid r \in R\} = \mathbb{K} \cdot \bar{x}^2$$

A *homomorphism* of R -modules is a group homomorphism $\phi : M \rightarrow N$ such that $\phi(rm) = r\phi(m)$ for all $r \in R$ and $m \in M$. Two R -modules M and N are *isomorphic* if and only if there exist R -module homomorphisms $\phi : M \rightarrow N$ and $\psi : N \rightarrow M$ such that $\phi \circ \psi = \text{Id}_N$ and $\psi \circ \phi = \text{Id}_M$. Equivalently, there is a bijective homomorphism of R -modules $\phi : M \rightarrow N$. We call such maps *isomorphisms* of R -modules. If $\phi : M \rightarrow N$ is a homomorphism of R -modules, there are two natural submodules associated to it: its *kernel* and its *image*:

$$\ker(\phi) := \{m \in M \mid \phi(m) = 0_N\} \subseteq M \quad \text{and} \quad \text{img}(\phi) := \{\phi(m) \mid m \in M\} \subseteq N.$$

One should readily check that both the kernel and image of a module homomorphism are submodules. As with linear maps, group homomorphisms, and ring homomorphisms, the kernel measures the failure of injectivity and the image measures the failure of surjectivity. Given a submodule $N \subseteq M$, the quotient abelian group M/N inherits an R -module structure via

$$r(m + N) := rm + N.$$

Well-definedness uses that N is a submodule, not merely a subgroup. The projection $\pi : M \rightarrow M/N$ is a homomorphism with $\ker(\pi) = N$. The quotient M/N is the module obtained by forcing $N = 0$. Precisely: if $f : M \rightarrow P$ is a homomorphism with $N \subseteq \ker(f)$, there is a unique $\bar{f} : M/N \rightarrow P$ with $f = \bar{f} \circ \pi$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} M & \xrightarrow{f} & P \\ \pi \downarrow & \nearrow \bar{f} & \\ M/N & & \end{array}$$

Phrased differently, there is a natural isomorphism

$$\text{Hom}_R(M/N, P) \cong \{f \in \text{Hom}_R(M, P) \mid N \subseteq \ker(f)\};$$

That is, homomorphisms out of M/N are exactly homomorphisms out of M that kill N . This is usually summarized as the First Isomorphism Theorem.

Theorem 0.1 (First Isomorphism Theorem). *Every homomorphism $\phi : M \rightarrow N$ of R -modules induces an isomorphism*

$$M / \ker(\phi) \xrightarrow{\sim} \text{img}(\phi), \quad m + \ker(\phi) \mapsto \phi(m).$$

In other words, quotienting by the kernel accounts for all the redundancy: every surjection is a quotient map.

Theorem 0.2 (Third Isomorphism Theorem). *Let $N \subseteq M$ be a submodule and $\pi: M \twoheadrightarrow M/N$ the projection. There is an inclusion-preserving bijection*

$$\{\text{submodules of } M \text{ containing } N\} \xleftrightarrow{1:1} \{\text{submodules of } M/N\}$$

given by $L \mapsto L/N = \pi(L)$ with inverse $\bar{L} \mapsto \pi^{-1}(\bar{L})$. Moreover, for $N \subseteq L \subseteq M$:

$$M/L \cong (M/N)/(L/N).$$

The correspondence says that the submodule lattice of M/N is the interval $[N, M]$ in the submodule lattice of M . The supplementary isomorphism $(M/N)/(L/N) \cong M/L$ is sometimes called the *Third Isomorphism Theorem*: quotienting in two stages is the same as quotienting all at once.

Problem 4. Basic Examples of Module Homomorphisms.

1. If $\mathbb{K}$ is a field, explain why a homomorphism of $\mathbb{K}$ -modules is the same as a $\mathbb{K}$ -linear map.
2. Explain why a homomorphism of $\mathbb{Z}$ -modules is the same as a homomorphism of abelian groups.

Solution.

1. If $\mathbb{K}$ is a field, we know that a $\mathbb{K}$ -module is a $\mathbb{K}$ -vector space. Moreover, by definition, a homomorphism $\varphi : N \rightarrow M$ where N, M are $\mathbb{K}$ -modules ($\mathbb{K}$ -vector spaces) has the following property: for any $r, s \in \mathbb{K}$ and $a, b \in N$ we have,

$$\varphi(ra + sb) = \varphi(ra) + \varphi(sb) = r\varphi(a) + s\varphi(b)$$

which is the condition defining a $\mathbb{K}$ -linear map.

2. We proved in Problem 2 that $\mathbb{Z}$ -modules are the same as abelian groups, then any $\mathbb{Z}$ -module homomorphism must preserve the group operation and hence is the same as an abelian group homomorphism.

Problem 5. Cyclic Modules & Annihilators. Let M be an R -module. The *annihilator* of an element $m \in M$ is $\text{Ann}_R(m) := \{r \in R \mid rm = 0\}$.

1. Prove that $\text{Ann}_R(m)$ is an ideal of R .
2. What is $\text{Ann}_R(0_M)$?
3. Consider the multiplication by m function:

$$\phi_m : R \rightarrow M \quad \text{given by} \quad r \mapsto rm.$$

Prove that ϕ_m is a homomorphism of R -modules.

4. Show that $\ker(\phi_m) = \text{Ann}_R(m)$ and $\text{img}(\phi_m) = Rm$.
5. Prove that a submodule $N \subseteq M$ is cyclic if and only if $N \cong R/I$ for some ideal $I \subseteq R$.

Solution.

1. To show that $\text{Ann}_R(m)$ is an ideal of R we need to check that it is a subgroup under addition, and is closed under multiplication from elements in R .

(a) **Identity:** Note that $0 \in \text{Ann}_R(m)$ since $0 \cdot m = 0$.

(b) **Closure under Addition and Inverses:** If $a, b \in \text{Ann}_R(m)$, then

$$(a - b)m = am - bm = 0 - 0 = 0$$

so $a - b \in \text{Ann}_R(m)$.

Hence $\text{Ann}_R(m)$ is a subgroup of $(R, +)$.

(c) Let $r \in R$ and $a \in \text{Ann}_R(m)$. Then

$$(ra)m = r(am) = r \cdot 0 = 0$$

so $ra \in \text{Ann}_R(m)$.

Hence $\text{Ann}_R(m)$ is an ideal of R .

2. $\text{Ann}_R(0_M) = \{r \in R \mid r0_M = 0\} = R$. That is, $\text{Ann}_R(0_M)$ is the whole ring.
3. Let $a, b \in R$. Consider

$$\phi_m(a + b) = (a + b)m = am + bm = \phi_m(a) + \phi_m(b)$$

Hence ϕ_m is a group homomorphism. And, for any $r, a \in R$ we have,

$$\phi_m(ra) = (ra)m = r(am) = r\phi_m(a)$$

Hence, ϕ_m is a homomorphism of R -modules.

4. $\ker(\phi_m) = \{r \in R \mid rm = 0\}$ which is precisely the definition of $\text{Ann}_R(m)$.

And $\text{im}(\phi_m) = \{rm \mid r \in R\} = Rm$.

5. ($\implies$)

Assume submodule $N \subseteq M$ is cyclic. Then $N = R \cdot m$ for some $m \in M$. From part (4) we know that $\ker(\phi_m) = \text{Ann}_R(m)$ and $\text{im}(\phi_m) = Rm$, that is by the first isomorphism theorem,

$$N = Rm = \text{im}(\phi_m) \cong R / \ker(\phi_m) = R / \text{Ann}_R(m)$$

where we know that $\text{Ann}_R(m)$ is an ideal in R (part 1)

($\impliedby$)

Assume $N \cong R/I$ for some ideal $I \subseteq R$. Then there exists some isomorphism of R -modules $\varphi : R/I \rightarrow N$. Note that every element in R/I can be written as, $r(1 + I)$ for some $r \in R$ and therefore every element of N is of the form

$$\varphi(r(1 + I)) = r\varphi(1 + I)$$

Let $\varphi(1 + I) = n \in N$. That is every element is of the form rn for some $r \in R$, then $N \subseteq Rn$. Moreover since $n \in N$ and N is closed under scalar multiplication we have $Rn \subseteq N$. Hence, N is cyclic.

Let $\{M_i\}_{i \in I}$ be a family of R -modules indexed by a set I . The *direct product* is

$$\prod_{i \in I} M_i = \{(m_i)_{i \in I} \mid m_i \in M_i\},$$

with componentwise addition and scalar multiplication. The *direct sum* is the submodule

$$\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i = \left\{ (m_i)_{i \in I} \in \prod_{i \in I} M_i \mid m_i = 0 \text{ for all but finitely many } i \right\}.$$

For each $j \in I$ there is a projection map π_j and an inclusion map ι_j :

$$\pi_j : \prod_{i \in I} M_i \rightarrow M_j, \quad ((m_i))_{i \in I} \mapsto m_j,$$

and

$$\iota_j : M_j \rightarrow \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i, \quad m \mapsto (0, \dots, 0, m, 0, \dots).$$

The product is characterized by maps to the factors, while the direct sum is characterized by maps from the summands. These are the universal properties that make products and sums so useful.

Problem 6. Direct Sums and Products of Modules.

Let $\{M_i\}_{i \in I}$ be a family of R -modules indexed by a set I .

1. Prove that both $\prod_{i \in I} M_i$ and $\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$ are R -modules.
2. Explain why, if I is finite, $\prod_{i \in I} M_i = \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$.
3. Consider the $\mathbb{Z}$ -modules $M_n = \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ for $n \geq 1$. Describe explicitly an element of $\prod_{n=1}^{\infty} M_n$ that is not an element of $\bigoplus_{n=1}^{\infty} M_n$.
4. Let $M_i = R$ for all $i \in \mathbb{N}$. Show that the submodule of $\prod_{i \in \mathbb{N}} R$ generated by the standard basis vectors $e_1, e_2, e_3, \dots$ is $\bigoplus_{i \in \mathbb{N}} R$, not the whole product, provided $R \neq 0$.
5. For two modules M and N , write down the inclusion maps ι_M, ι_N and projection maps π_M, π_N for $M \oplus N$. Verify the following identities

$$\pi_M \circ \iota_M = \text{Id}_M, \quad \pi_N \circ \iota_N = \text{Id}_N,$$

$$\pi_M \circ \iota_N = 0, \quad \pi_N \circ \iota_M = 0, \text{ and } \iota_M \circ \pi_M + \iota_N \circ \pi_N = \text{Id}_{M \oplus N}.$$

Solution.

1. Let $f, g, h \in \prod_{i \in I} M_i$ and $r, s \in R$. We can see that $\prod_{i \in I} M_i$ is an abelian group under componentwise addition because each M_i is an abelian group under addition by definition. Now we check the scalar multiplication:

(a) **Closure:** Since $r \cdot f(i) \in M_i$ for all i , $r \cdot f \in \prod_{i \in I} M_i$.

(b) **Associativity:** Since $(rs)f(i) = r(sf(i))$ for all i , $(rs)f = r(sf)$.

(c) **Distributivity over Module Addition:** Since for all i we have,

$$r(f(i) + g(i)) = r(f(i)) + r(g(i))$$

we get

$$r(f + g) = rf + rg$$

(d) **Distributivity over Ring Addition:** Since for all i we have,

$$(r + s)f(i) = r(f(i)) + s(f(i))$$

we get

$$(r + s)f = rf + sf$$

(e) **Unitality:** Since for all i we have $1_R \cdot f(i) = f(i)$ we get

$$1_R \cdot f = f$$

Since $\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i \subseteq \prod_{i \in I} M_i$ it suffices to show that $\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$ is a submodule. Let $f, g \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$ and $r \in R$.

- (a) **Non-empty:** $0 \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$
 - (b) **Closure under Addition:** Since both f and g have only finitely many non-zero entries, their sum also has finitely many non-zero entries and hence $f + g \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$.
 - (c) **Closure under Scalar Multiplication:** Since both f has only finitely many non-zero entries, and $r \cdot 0_M = 0$ the product $r \cdot f$ also has finitely many non-zero entries and hence $r \cdot f \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$.
2. We know that $\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i \subseteq \prod_{i \in I} M_i$, so we only need to show the opposite containment. But if I is finite, every element $f \in \prod_{i \in I} M_i$ only has finitely many non-zero entries and hence by definition $f \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$. Thus, $\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i = \prod_{i \in I} M_i$.
 3. Note that $1 \in \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ for all $n \geq 1$. Then the element $(1, 1, 1, \dots) \in \prod_{n=1}^{\infty} M_n$ but it is not in $\bigoplus_{n=1}^{\infty} M_n$ because it has infinitely many non-zero entries.
 4. An element of the submodule generated by $\{e_i\}$ is a finite R -linear combination, and hence has only finitely many non-zero entries and hence is in $\bigoplus_{i \in \mathbb{N}} R$. Since we are not allowed infinite sums elements like $(1, 1, 1, \dots) = \sum_{i=1}^{\infty} e_i$ are not in the generated submodule.
 5. We have,

$$\begin{aligned}\pi_M : M \bigoplus N &\rightarrow M, & \pi_M(m, n) &= m \\ \pi_N : M \bigoplus N &\rightarrow N, & \pi_N(m, n) &= n\end{aligned}$$

And,

$$\begin{aligned}\iota_M : M &\rightarrow M \bigoplus N, & \iota_M(m) &= (m, 0) \\ \iota_N : N &\rightarrow M \bigoplus N, & \iota_N(n) &= (0, n)\end{aligned}$$

Then,

$$\begin{aligned}\pi_M \circ \iota_M(m) &= \pi_M(0, m) = m = \text{id}_M(m), \\ \pi_N \circ \iota_N(n) &= \pi_N(0, n) = n = \text{id}_N(n), \\ \pi_M \circ \iota_N(n) &= \pi_M(0, n) = 0, \\ \pi_N \circ \iota_M(m) &= \pi_N(m, 0) = 0,\end{aligned}$$

$$(\iota_M \circ \pi_M + \iota_N \circ \pi_N)((m, n)) = \iota_M(m) + \iota_N(n) = (m, 0) + (0, n) = (m, n) = \text{Id}_{M \oplus N}(m, n).$$

Problem 7. Universal Properties of Products and Sums.

Let $\{M_i\}_{i \in I}$ be a family of R -modules indexed by I .

1. Let L be an R -module and suppose that for every $i \in I$ we are given a homomorphism $\phi_i : L \rightarrow M_i$. Prove that there exists a unique homomorphism $\phi : L \rightarrow \prod_{i \in I} M_i$ such that the following diagram commutes for all $i \in I$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} L & \xrightarrow{\phi} & \prod_{i \in I} M_i \\ & \searrow \phi_i & \downarrow \pi_i \\ & & M_i \end{array} \quad .$$

2. Let L be an R -module and suppose that for every $i \in I$ we are given a homomorphism $\psi_i : M_i \rightarrow L$. Prove that there exists a unique homomorphism $\psi : \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i \rightarrow L$ such that the following diagram commutes for all $i \in I$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i & \xrightarrow{\psi} & L \\ \uparrow \iota_i & \nearrow \psi_i & \\ M_i & & \end{array} \quad .$$

3. Deduce natural isomorphisms of R -modules

$$\operatorname{Hom}_R \left(L, \prod_{i \in I} M_i \right) \cong \prod_{i \in I} \operatorname{Hom}_R(L, M_i)$$

and

$$\operatorname{Hom}_R \left(\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i, L \right) \cong \prod_{i \in I} \operatorname{Hom}_R(M_i, L).$$

4. Explain why a family of maps $\psi_i : M_i \rightarrow L$ does not generally define a map $\prod_{i \in I} M_i \rightarrow L$. Use the case $M_i = L = \mathbb{Z}$ and $\psi_i = \operatorname{Id}_{\mathbb{Z}}$ to illustrate the problem.
5. When I is finite, explain why the two universal properties describe the same module. This is why finite direct sums are also finite direct products.

Solution.

1. **Existence:** We define $\phi : L \rightarrow \prod_{i \in I} M_i$ as follows

$$\phi(l) = (\phi_1(l), \dots, \phi_i(l), \dots)$$

This is a well-defined homomorphism because each ϕ_i is a homomorphism.

Uniqueness: Let $\psi : L \rightarrow \prod_{i \in I} M_i$ be another such homomorphism. Then we have $\pi_i \circ \psi(l) = \phi_i(l) = \pi_i \circ \phi(l)$ for all $i \in I$ and $l \in L$. Since π_i is well-defined, this means $\psi = \phi$.

2. **Existence:** We define $\psi : \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i \rightarrow L$ as follows

$$\psi(f) = \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(f(i))$$

Note that this sum is well-defined since for all $f \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$ only finitely many $f(i) \neq 0$. This is a homomorphism since,

$$\begin{aligned} \psi(f + g) &= \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(f(i) + g(i)) \\ &= \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(f(i)) + \psi_i(g(i)) \\ &= \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(f(i)) + \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(g(i)) \\ &= \psi(f) + \psi(g) \end{aligned}$$

And,

$$\begin{aligned} \psi(r \cdot f) &= \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(r \cdot f(i)) \\ &= \sum_{i \in I} r \cdot \psi_i(f(i)) \\ &= r \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(f(i)) \\ &= r \cdot \psi(f) \end{aligned}$$

Uniqueness: Let $\phi : \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i \rightarrow L$ be another homomorphism such that $\phi \circ \iota_i = \psi_i$ for all $i \in I$. For any $f \in \bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i$, since f has only finitely many non-zero entries we can write $f = \sum_{i \in I} \iota_i(f(i))$, and so

$$\phi(f) = \sum_{i \in I} \phi(\iota_i(f(i))) = \sum_{i \in I} \psi_i(f(i)) = \psi(f)$$

Since f was arbitrary, $\phi = \psi$.

3. From (1) and (2) we can see that there exists a bijection between homomorphisms $\phi \leftrightarrow (\phi_i)$ and $\psi \leftrightarrow (\psi(i))$. Then we define homomorphisms:

$$\Phi : \text{Hom}_R \left(L, \prod_{i \in I} M_i \right) \rightarrow \prod_{i \in I} \text{Hom}_R(L, M_i), \quad \Phi(\phi) = (\pi_i \circ \phi)_{i \in I}$$

$$\Psi : \text{Hom}_R \left(\bigoplus_{i \in I} M_i, L \right) \rightarrow \prod_{i \in I} \text{Hom}_R(M_i, L), \quad \Psi(\phi) = (\psi \circ \iota_i)_{i \in I}$$

Since the universal properties say that every family (ϕ_i) and (ψ_i) come from unique ϕ and ψ respectively, the homomorphisms Φ and Ψ are bijective.

4. Let $M_i = L = \mathbb{Z}$ and $\psi_i = \text{id}_{\mathbb{Z}}$. Then $f = (1, 1, 1, \dots)$ is an element in $\prod_{i \in I} M_i$. Note that the number of non-zero entries in f can be infinite. Then, the map

$$\psi(f) = \sum_{i \in I} \text{id}_{\mathbb{Z}}(f(i)) = \sum_{i \in I} 1$$

is not defined because it describes an infinite sum. Hence, a family of maps $\psi_i : M_i \rightarrow L$ does not generally define a map $\prod_{i \in I} M_i \rightarrow L$.

5. This is clear from Problem 6 (2).

Over a field, every module (i.e. vector space) has a basis, and a linear map is determined by its values on a basis. Over a general ring, modules need not have bases at all—but those that do are of fundamental importance. The goal of this section is to set up the theory of free modules and to understand precisely how they differ from vector spaces.

Let M be an R -module. A subset $B \subseteq M$ *generates* (or *spans*) M if every element of M can be written as a finite R -linear combination of elements of B , i.e. if

$$M = \left\{ \sum_{i=1}^n r_i m_i \mid n \geq 0, r_i \in R, m_i \in B \right\}.$$

We say B is *linearly independent* if, whenever $m_1, \dots, m_n \in B$ are distinct and $\sum_{i=1}^n r_i m_i = 0$, we have $r_i = 0$ for all i . A *basis* for M is a subset that is both generating and linearly independent, or equivalently, a subset $\{b_s\}_{s \in S}$ such that every element of M can be written *uniquely* as a finite R -linear combination $\sum_s r_s b_s$.

Over a field, these notions interact exactly as in undergraduate linear algebra: every spanning set contains a basis, every linearly independent set extends to one, and all bases have the same cardinality. Over a general ring, the first two statements can fail; in particular, many modules do not admit bases at all. A module that does admit a basis is called *free*. Given a set S , the *free R -module on S* is

$$R^{(S)} := \bigoplus_{s \in S} R.$$

Concretely, $R^{(S)}$ consists of all functions $S \rightarrow R$ with finite support. It has a distinguished element e_s for each $s \in S$, where e_s has a 1 in the s -coordinate and 0 elsewhere. Every element of $R^{(S)}$ can then be written uniquely as a finite sum

$$\sum_{s \in S} r_s e_s,$$

so $\{e_s \mid s \in S\}$ is a basis, called the *standard basis*. When $S = \{1, \dots, n\}$ we write R^n instead of $R^{(S)}$.

The key feature of a free module is that a homomorphism out of it is completely determined by where the basis goes. Precisely: for every function of sets $\alpha: S \rightarrow M$ (where M is any R -module), there is a unique R -module homomorphism $\tilde{\alpha}: R^{(S)} \rightarrow M$ such that $\tilde{\alpha}(e_s) = \alpha(s)$ for all $s \in S$. In categorical language, the functor $S \mapsto R^{(S)}$ is left adjoint to the forgetful functor from R -modules to sets. This universal property characterizes $R^{(S)}$ up to unique isomorphism and is the reason free modules play a role analogous to that of vector spaces—they are the modules we can map out of “for free.”

Problem 8. Free Modules and Their Universal Property.

1. Verify directly that every element of $R^{(S)}$ can be written uniquely as a finite R -linear combination of the standard basis elements e_s .
2. Prove the universal property of $R^{(S)}$ stated above.
3. Deduce that there is a natural isomorphism

$$\text{Hom}_R(R^{(S)}, M) \cong \prod_{s \in S} M.$$

Why is the right side a product rather than a direct sum?

4. Show that an R -module M is generated by $m_1, \dots, m_n$ if and only if there is a surjective homomorphism $R^n \rightarrow M$ sending e_i to m_i .
5. Conclude that every finitely generated R -module is a quotient of a finite free module.
6. More generally, show that every R -module is a quotient of a free R -module.
7. For $M = R/I$, write M as a quotient of a free module and identify the kernel.
8. For $R = \mathbb{K}[x]$ and $M = R/\langle x^3 \rangle$, describe M as a module with one generator and one relation.

Solution.

1. Let $f \in R^{(S)}$. Then by definition $f(s) \neq 0$ for only finitely many $s \in S$. So we can write $f = \sum_{s \in S} f(s) \cdot e_s = \sum_{s \in S} r_s \cdot e_s$ for some $r_s \in R$, which is a finite sum and hence every element of $R^{(S)}$ can be written uniquely as a finite R -linear combination of the standard basis elements.

Uniqueness: Suppose $f = \sum_{s \in S} r'_s e_s = \sum_{s \in S} r_s e_s$. Then comparing the s -th element gives us $r'_s e_s = r_s e_s \implies r'_s = r_s$. Hence the linear combination is unique.

2. **Existence:** Let $\alpha : S \rightarrow M$ be a set map. For each $s \in S$, define $\psi_s : R \rightarrow M$ by $\psi_s(r) = r \cdot \alpha(s)$. This is an R -module homomorphism since

$$\psi_s(r + r') = (r + r')\alpha(s) = r\alpha(s) + r'\alpha(s) = \psi_s(r) + \psi_s(r')$$

and $\psi_s(rr') = rr'\alpha(s) = r\psi_s(r')$. Since $R^{(S)} = \bigoplus_{s \in S} R$, by the universal property of the direct sum there exists a unique R -module homomorphism $\tilde{\alpha} : R^{(S)} \rightarrow M$ such

that $\tilde{\alpha} \circ \iota_s = \psi_s$ for all $s \in S$. In particular, $\tilde{\alpha}(e_s) = \psi_s(1_R) = \alpha(s)$, so the diagram

$$\begin{array}{ccc} R^{(S)} & \xrightarrow{\tilde{\alpha}} & M \\ \iota_s \uparrow & \nearrow \alpha & \\ S & & \end{array}$$

commutes for all $s \in S$.

Uniqueness: Any R -module homomorphism $\phi : R^{(S)} \rightarrow M$ satisfying $\phi(e_s) = \alpha(s)$ for all $s \in S$ must satisfy

$$\phi\left(\sum_{s \in S} r_s e_s\right) = \sum_{s \in S} r_s \phi(e_s) = \sum_{s \in S} r_s \alpha(s) = \tilde{\alpha}\left(\sum_{s \in S} r_s e_s\right).$$

Since every element of $R^{(S)}$ is a finite R -linear combination of the e_s , we conclude $\phi = \tilde{\alpha}$.

3. By the universal property, every homomorphism $\phi : R^{(S)} \rightarrow M$ is uniquely determined by $\phi(e_s) \in M$ for each $s \in S$. Then the map,

$$\text{Hom}_R(R^{(S)}, M) \rightarrow \prod_{s \in S} M, \quad \phi \mapsto (\phi(e_s))_{s \in S}$$

is a bijection. There is no finiteness restriction on how many $\phi(e_s) \neq 0$, hence the right-hand side must allow non-zero infinite tuples and hence is $\prod_{s \in S} M$.

4. ($\implies$)

Assume M is a R -module generated by $m_1, \dots, m_n$. Then from part (3) we know there exists a homomorphism $\phi : R^n \rightarrow M$ that sends $e_i \mapsto m_i$ for all $i \in \{1, \dots, n\}$. This homomorphism is surjective because all elements of M are finite linear combinations of m_i .

- ($\impliedby$)

Assume there exists a surjective homomorphism $\phi : R^n \rightarrow M$. Then for any $m \in M$, surjectivity gives some $x \in R^n$ with $\phi(x) = m$ and writing $x = \sum r_i e_i$ gives $m = \phi(\sum r_i e_i) = \sum r_i \phi(e_i)$. Hence, M is generated by $\{\phi(e_1), \dots, \phi(e_n)\}$.

5. Let M be a finitely-generated R -module. Then from part (5) we know there exists some surjective homomorphism $\phi : R^n \twoheadrightarrow M$ for some $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Then by the first isomorphism theorem we have an induced isomorphism,

$$\bar{\phi} : R^n / \ker(\phi) \cong M$$

6. Let M be a R -module, and define $S = M$. Then there exists a homomorphism $\phi : R^{(M)} \rightarrow M$ that sends $e_m \mapsto m$. Again, by the first isomorphism theorem there is an induced homomorphism $\bar{\phi}$,

$$\bar{\phi} : R^{(M)} / \ker(\phi) \cong M$$

7. Let $S = \{1\}$. Then we have $\phi : R^{(S)} \rightarrow R/I = M$ with $\ker(\phi) = I$.
8. M is generated by $\bar{1} \in M$ and obeys the relation $x^3 = 0$.

Problem 9. Free Modules Are Not Quite Vector Spaces.

1. Show that $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is not a free $\mathbb{Z}$ -module for any $n > 1$.
2. More generally, if R is an integral domain and $0 \neq I \subsetneq R$ is an ideal, show that R/I is not a free R -module.
3. In the $\mathbb{Z}$ -module $\mathbb{Z}$, show that $\{2, 3\}$ is a generating set but not a basis.
4. In the $\mathbb{Z}$ -module $\mathbb{Z}$, show that $\{2\}$ is linearly independent but does not generate $\mathbb{Z}$.
5. Let $R = \mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$. Show that the element $\bar{2} \in R$ is nonzero but not part of a basis for the free R -module R .
6. Explain why the previous examples show that bases over rings behave differently from bases over fields.

Solution.

1. Suppose for contradiction that $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -module with basis B . Then B must be linearly independent, meaning whenever $m_1, \dots, m_k \in B$, are distinct and $\sum_{i=1}^k r_i m_i = 0$ we have $r_i = 0$ for all i . But for any $m \in B \subseteq \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ we have $n \cdot m = 0$ in $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ with $n \neq 0 \in \mathbb{Z}$ contradicting linear independence. Hence $\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ admits no basis and is not a free $\mathbb{Z}$ -module.
2. Suppose for contradiction that R/I is a free R -module with basis B . Since $I \neq 0$, pick some $0 \neq a \in I$. Then for any $m \in B \subseteq R/I$ we have $a \cdot m = 0 \in R/I$, with $a \neq 0$ thus contradicting linear independence. Hence R/I admits no basis and is not a free R -module.
3. $\{2, 3\}$ is a generating set since $3 - 2 = 1$ and 1 is a generator for $\mathbb{Z}$. But $\{2, 3\}$ is not a basis $3 \cdot 2 + (-2) \cdot 3 = 0$, where $3, -2 \neq 0$. Thus violating linear independence. Hence, $\{2, 3\}$ is not a basis.
4. $\{2\}$ is linearly independent because if $r \cdot 2 = 0$ then $r = 0$ since $\mathbb{Z}$ is an integral domain. But $\{2\}$ is not a generating set because no finite linear combination of $\{2\}$ gives us 1.
5. $\bar{2} \neq 0$ since $2 \not\equiv 0 \pmod{6}$, and $\bar{2} \cdot \bar{3} = 0$ and hence $\bar{2}$ fails linear independence and cannot be part of a basis.
6. Over a field every linearly-independent set extends to a basis and every spanning set contains a basis. The previous examples show that both properties fail over general rings.

Problem 10. Matrices and Maps Between Finite Free Modules.

1. Let $A = (a_{ij})$ be an $m \times n$ matrix with entries in R . Define a homomorphism

$$\phi_A : R^n \rightarrow R^m, \quad e_j \mapsto \sum_{i=1}^m a_{ij} e_i.$$

Prove that every homomorphism $R^n \rightarrow R^m$ arises uniquely in this way.

2. Under this correspondence, prove that composition of homomorphisms corresponds to multiplication of matrices.
3. When $R = \mathbb{K}$ is a field, explain how this recovers the usual matrix description of linear maps between finite-dimensional vector spaces.
4. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$ and view A as a homomorphism $\mathbb{Z}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}^2$. Describe $\text{coker}(A) = \mathbb{Z}^2 / \text{img}(A)$.
5. Let $R = \mathbb{K}[x]$ and consider multiplication by x as a map $R^2 \rightarrow R^2$. Write its matrix with respect to the standard basis, and compute its cokernel.

Solution.

1. **Existence:** By the universal property of free modules, a homomorphism $\phi : R^n \rightarrow R^m$ is determined by where it sends the basis vectors $e_1, \dots, e_n$. Then, for all j , $\phi(e_j) \in R^m$ can be written as

$$\phi(e_j) = \sum_{i=1}^m a_{ij} e_i$$

for some $a_{ij} \in R$. Then we define $A = (a_{ij})$ to be a $m \times n$ matrix. Then $\phi = \phi_A$ by construction.

Uniqueness: The matrix A is unique since each entry a_{ij} is uniquely determined as a linear combination of the basis elements e_i , hence no two matrices give the same homomorphism.

Hence every homomorphism $R^n \rightarrow R^m$ arises uniquely in this way.

2. Let $\phi : R^n \rightarrow R^p$, $\psi : R^p \rightarrow R^m$ be two homomorphisms with corresponding matrices $A = (a_{kj})$, $B = (b_{ik})$ respectively. Then for each basis vector $e_j \in R^n$,

$$(\psi \circ \phi)(e_j) = \psi \left(\sum_{k=1}^p a_{kj} e_k \right) = \sum_{k=1}^p a_{kj} \psi(e_k) = \sum_{k=1}^p a_{kj} \sum_{i=1}^m b_{ik} e_i = \sum_{i=1}^m \left(\sum_{k=1}^p b_{ik} a_{kj} \right) e_i$$

The coefficient of e_i is $\sum_{k=1}^p b_{ik}a_{kj}$, which is exactly the (i, j) -entry of the matrix product BA . Since $\psi \circ \phi$ is determined by its values on the basis vectors, we conclude that $\psi \circ \phi$ corresponds to BA .

3. Let $R = \mathbb{K}$ be a field. Then a homomorphism $\phi : \mathbb{K}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{K}^m$ is a $\mathbb{K}$ -linear map and the correspondence $\phi \rightarrow A$ is the usual representation of a linear map by its matrix with respect to the standard bases.
4. Note that $A(e_1) = (2, 0)$ and $A(e_2) = (0, 3)$. Then we have,

$$\text{img}(A) = \{(2a, 3b) \mid a, b \in \mathbb{Z}\} = 2\mathbb{Z} \oplus 3\mathbb{Z}$$

$$\text{Hence, } \text{coker}(A) = \mathbb{Z}^2 / \text{img}(A) = \mathbb{Z}/2\mathbb{Z} \oplus \mathbb{Z}/3\mathbb{Z}$$

5. Let A be the matrix that corresponds to multiplication by x . Then, $A = \begin{pmatrix} x & 0 \\ 0 & x \end{pmatrix}$, and $\text{coker}(A) = R^2 / \text{img}(A) = \mathbb{K} \oplus \mathbb{K}$.

For two R -modules M and N , we write $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ for the set of R -module homomorphisms $M \rightarrow N$. Since R is commutative, $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ is itself an R -module: addition and scalar multiplication are defined pointwise by

$$(\phi + \psi)(m) = \phi(m) + \psi(m), \quad (r\phi)(m) = r\phi(m).$$

This construction is one of the most important ways of building new modules from old ones. There is already a great deal to understand: Hom out of a free module is easy, Hom out of a quotient records annihilators, and Hom interacts cleanly with direct sums and products through their universal properties.

Problem 11. $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ as a Module.

1. Prove that $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ is an abelian group under pointwise addition. What is the zero element?
2. Prove that the formula $(r\phi)(m) = r\phi(m)$ makes $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ into an R -module.
3. Show that evaluation at $1 \in R$ defines an isomorphism of R -modules

$$\text{Hom}_R(R, M) \cong M.$$

4. More generally, prove that

$$\text{Hom}_R(R/I, M) \cong \{m \in M \mid Im = 0\}.$$

The isomorphism should again be given by evaluation at $\bar{1} \in R/I$.

5. Deduce that $\text{Hom}_R(R^n, M) \cong M^n$.
6. Prove that $\text{End}_R(R) \cong R$ as rings, where the ring structure on $\text{End}_R(R)$ is given by addition and composition.
7. If $I \subseteq R$ is an ideal, identify $\text{Hom}_R(R/I, R)$ in terms of an annihilator ideal of R .

Solution.

1. Let $\phi, \psi \in \text{Hom}_R(M, N)$. Then we define,

$$(\phi + \psi)(m) := \phi(m) + \psi(m) \quad \forall m \in M$$

Then since ϕ, ψ are homomorphisms and addition in N is commutative, for $m, m' \in M$ we have,

$$\begin{aligned} (\phi + \psi)(m + m') &= \phi(m + m') + \psi(m + m') \\ &= \phi(m) + \phi(m') + \psi(m) + \psi(m') \\ &= \phi(m) + \psi(m) + \phi(m') + \psi(m') \\ &= (\phi + \psi)(m) + (\phi + \psi)(m') \end{aligned}$$

Also note that associativity and commutativity are inherited from N , and the additive inverse of ϕ , $(-\phi)(m) := -\phi(m)$ is well-defined. The zero element is the zero map, $0(m) := 0_N$ for all $m \in M$,

$$(f + 0)(m) = f(m) + 0(m) = f(m) + 0_N = f(m)$$

Hence, $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ is an abelian group under pointwise addition.

2. We know that $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ is an abelian group, and the formula $(r\phi)(m) = r\phi(m)$ shows that $\text{Hom}_R(M, N)$ is closed under scalar multiplication,

$$(r\phi)(sm) = r\phi(sm) = rs\phi(m) = sr\phi(m) = s(r\phi)(m)$$

All other module properties follow, showing that it is a R -module.

3. Define a map $\eta : \text{Hom}_R(R, M) \rightarrow M$, where $\phi \mapsto \phi(1) = m$ for some $m \in M$. This map is injective since the homomorphism is completely determined by where 1 goes, so if $\phi(1) = \psi(1) \implies \phi = \psi$.

To show that this map is a surjection we must show that there exists a homomorphism $\phi_m \in \text{Hom}_R(R, M)$ such that $\phi_m(1) = m$ for all $m \in M$. So, we define

$$\phi_m(r) = rm \quad \forall r \in R$$

and show that ϕ_m is a homomorphism:

- $\phi_m(s \cdot r) = (s \cdot r)m = s(rm) = s\phi_m(r)$
- $\phi_m(s + r) = (s + r)m = sm + rm = \phi_m(s) + \phi_m(r)$

So for every $m \in M$ there exists a homomorphism ϕ_m that maps to it under η .

4. Similarly, we define a map $\eta : \text{Hom}_R(R/I, M) \rightarrow \{m \in M \mid Im = 0\}$, where $\phi \mapsto \phi(\bar{1}) = \phi(1 + I)$. This map is well-defined since for any $a \in I$ we have,

$$a\phi(1 + I) = \phi(a + aI) = \phi(\bar{0}) = 0$$

This map is injective since the homomorphism is completely determined by where $\bar{1}$ goes, so

$$\eta(\phi) = \eta(\psi) \implies \phi(1 + I) = \psi(1 + I) \implies \phi = \psi$$

To show that this map is a surjection we define

$$\phi_m(r + I) = rm \quad \forall r \in R$$

and show that ϕ_m is a well-defined homomorphism:

- Let $s + I = r + I$ then, $s - r \in I$ and

$$(s - r)m = 0 \implies sm = rm \implies \phi_m(s + I) = \phi_m(r + I)$$

- $\phi_m(s(r + I)) = \phi(sr + I) = srm = s\phi(r + I)$
- $\phi_m((s + r) + I) = (s + r)m = sm + rm = \phi_m(s) + \phi_m(r)$

So for every $m \in M$ such that $mI = 0$ there exists a homomorphism ϕ_m that maps to it under η .

5.